Hanna Sistek

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Research Interests

Drawing on a decade-plus career as an international journalist, and motivated by the global trend of democratic backsliding, my work investigates the effects of digital technologies on democratic discourse and political accountability, and more recently, whether AI can help improve political communication skills. Methodologically, my work integrates qualitative, quantitative, and computational approaches, including cross-national institutional and statistical analysis, interviews, survey experiments, text analysis (including LLM-assisted analysis through API calls), and human-centered design.

Academic Appointments

2026-2027 | **Postdoctoral Civil Discourse Fellow**
Edmond & Lily Safra Center for Ethics
Harvard University, Cambridge, MA

2026- | **Research Affiliate**
Governance and Responsible AI Lab (GRAIL)
Student Perspectives on AI Research & Knowledge Lab (SPARK), John Martinson Honors College
Purdue University, West Lafayette, IN

2025-2026 | **Postdoctoral Fellow**
Center for American Political History, Media, and Technology (CAPT) & Governance and Responsible AI Lab (GRAIL)
Purdue University, West Lafayette, IN

Education

2025 | **Ph.D. Political Science**
Purdue University, West Lafayette, IN
Major field: Comparative Politics
Minor fields: International Relations, Political Methodology
Dissertation: Structural Incentives for Politicians to Manipulate Domestic Opinion
Committee Members: Cherie D. Maestas (chair), Andy Baker, Mollie Cohen, Marcus Mann

2005 | **Journalism degree**
University of Gothenburg, Sweden

2003 | **B.S. Physical Therapy**
Lund University, Sweden
Exchange year, University of Melbourne, Australia (2002)

Peer-Reviewed Publications

** indicates a graduate student co-author, ‡ indicates a recent graduate (early-career) co-author.*

1. Hannah, Matthew, Jennifer Hoewe, **Hanna Sistek**, Taeik Kim*, and Dan Goldwasser. 2024. **"A mindfulness-based information literacy framework for the current information environment."** *Journal of Information Literacy, 18*(2).
[Named a Top 20 Article of 2024 by the Library Instruction Round Table of the American Library Association]

Working Papers

1. "Escalating Political Use of Disinformation: A New Reputational Theory Explaining Communication Changes in Democracies" *Revise & Resubmit*, Journal of Information Technology & Politics.
2. "Asymmetric Behavioral Shifts in Political Use of Disinformation: Case Study Interview Evidence From Europe"
3. "Asymmetric Accountability: Affective Polarization and Public Responses to Political Disinformation"
4. "Public Justifications of Political Disinformation in the United States: Comparing Manual Coding and Generative AI Classification" with Normand Péladeau and Priyadevi McNamara‡.

Works in Progress

1. "Using Large Language Models to practice cross-partisan dialogue" with Daniel Schiff (pre-analysis plan available upon request).
2. "AI as a Tool Against Partisan Disinformation"
3. "The Effect of Disinformation on Twittersphere Sentiment – Not Much When Debunked"

Research Software & Digital Projects

† indicates an undergraduate student team member

1. *ConvoLab*: Human-AI interaction application designed to let users practice having difficult political conversations with people they disagree with, using two AI agents.
Repository: https://github.com/GRAIL-center/ConvoLab. Current team: Nebras Alam†, Brinda Akuthota†, Frankie Fox†, Anuj Nair†, Jaskeerat Khosla† and Rohan Sunchu†.

Public Engagement

1. **CAPTivated** Podcast, Center for American Political History, Media, and Technology, Purdue University. Released February 5, 2026; new episodes biweekly. Participated in the first season. *Co-founder, Co-host, and Co-producer*.

Fellowships, Grants, and Awards

Academic Recognition

2026 | Best Dissertation Award. APSA Information Technology and Politics Section.

2026 | Honorable Mention, Thomas E. Patterson Best Dissertation Award. APSA Political Communication Section.

Teaching Awards

2024 | Outstanding Teaching Assistant. Department of Political Science, Purdue University.

2023 | Teaching Assistant of the Year. Purdue University chapter of Pi Sigma Alpha.

Grants and Fellowships

2024 | Rapoport Doctoral Dissertation Grant. *$15,000*

2024, 2020 | Summer Research Grants (Purdue Graduate School, Purdue Research Foundation). *Total: $10,400*

2022-2025 | Purdue University internal awards: Graduate Peer Reviewed Article Award; Graduate Grant Submission Award (multiple years); Institute for Information Literacy. *Total: $1,000*

2016 | Innovation in Development Reporting Grant, European Journalism Centre.
Project: The Price of Basmati. *€18,510*

2012 | Language Studies Grant (Arabic, in Cairo), Swedish Journalist Union. *$1,800*

2008 | Innovation Journalism Fellow, H-STAR Institute, Stanford University (Vinnova)

Travel Awards

2024-2026 | Conference travel awards from the Rapoport Family Foundation, the APSA Political Communication and European Politics and Society sections, the Southern Political Science Association, and Purdue University. *Total: $4,350*

Invited Talks

May 2026	"ConvoLab – building an AI dialogue coaching app". Applied Social Media Lab Forum at the Berkman Klein Center for Internet & Society, Harvard University
February 2026	"Using AI as a Research Assistant". Guest Lecture for COMM 140: Fundamentals of Media Communication, College of Liberal Arts and Sciences at University of Illinois Chicago
February 2026	"Using AI to ask Historical Questions". Workshop with Aaron Mendon-Plasek for the History Department, Purdue University
October 2025	"Navigating Political Violence News in the Digital Age". Center for C-SPAN Scholarship & Engagement (CCSE), Purdue University
October 2025	"Behind the Headlines". Joint seminar presentation with Sage Goodwin. Center for American Political History, Media, and Technology, Purdue University

Conference Presentations

RAD	2026 (poster) Rochester Area Democracy Conference, University of Rochester
SPSA	2026, 2025
PolComm	2026, 2025 APSA Political Communication Preconference
APSA	2026, 2025, 2024, 2023
RMCEPS	2025 (poster) Rebecca B. Morton Conference on Experimental Political Science, New York University
ISA	2025
MPSA	2026, 2025, 2024, 2023, 2022
WPSA	2023
ICTS	2023 International Conspiracy Theory Symposium, University of Miami

Teaching and Research Experience

Instructor of Record

Summer 22/23	**Introduction to International Relations**

Research Assistant

AY 2018/19 | **Editorial Assistant for *Politics, Groups, and Identities*.**

Teaching Assistant: Graduate level

Fa 24/Sp 25 | **Societal Impacts of AI**

Fa 24/Sp 25 | **Artificial Intelligence Policy, Governance, and Ethics**

Teaching Assistant: Undergraduate level

Fa 23, Sp 24 | **Introduction to Environmental Policy and Politics**

Sp 22, Fa 22, Sp 23 | **Global Green Politics**

Fall 2022 | **Comparative Environmental Policy and Politics**

Fall 2021 | **Introduction to Comparative Politics**

Fall 2021 | **Renewable Energy Politics Around the World**

Spring 2021 | **Cornerstone class on Transformative texts, Critical Thinking & Oral Communication II: Modern World "Democracy, Citizenship and Civic Duty"**

Fall 2021 | **Cornerstone class on Transformative texts, Critical Thinking and Oral Communication II: "Technology, Great Power, and Its Responsibilities"**

Spring 2020 | **Introduction to U.S. Foreign Policy**

Fall 2019 | **Introduction to International Relations**

Pedagogical Training

Summer 2022 | **Certificate in Foundations of College Teaching**
Purdue University

Mentoring

2025- | **ConvoLab undergraduate team**
Recruited and supervise a team of up to eight undergraduate developers and UX designers through GRAIL and, since 2026, the SPARK Lab at the John Martinson Honors College, Purdue University; one team member presented the project at APSA 2026.

AY 2023/24 Spring 2025 | **Political Science Research Collaboratory**
Mentored undergraduate research assistants on comparative research about media systems, academic writing and survey research. Purdue University

Selected Additional Training

May, 2026 | **Summer Institute in Computational Social Sciences**
University of Rochester, NY

April, 2026 | **Text Analytics in the Generative AI Era 2.0**
Normand Péladeau/Provalis Research, Chicago

January, 2026 | **AI-Assisted Qualitative Research**
Trena Paulus/KiND Institute, New Orleans

January, 2026 | **Experiments in the Social Sciences**
Donald Green/KiND Institute, New Orleans

September, 2025 | **Temporal ERGM for Network Panel Data**
Scott Duxbury, UNC/The Methodology Center at Purdue

January, 2025 | **Foundations in Machine Learning**
KiND Institute/SPSA workshop, Puerto Rico

January, 2025 | **Data Coding in Qualitative Research**
KiND Institute/SPSA workshop, Puerto Rico

Fall 2023 | **Qualitative In-depth Interview Method: A Quality Approach to Data Collection and Analysis Setup**
American Association for Public Opinion Research Short Course

Languages and Skills

Languages: Swedish, Czech (native); English (fluent); German (intermediate); French, Arabic (basic)
Software: R, Python, Git, LaTeX, Qualtrics, NVivo, Docker
Learning Management Systems: Blackboard, Brightspace

Service

Committees

2025-2026 | **Co-Organizer, first annual "Summit on Information, Technology and American Democracy"**
Public summit on AI, algorithms and the media ecosystem, Indianapolis, April 30, 2026. Organized by CAPT/GRAIL, Purdue University.

2025-2026 | **Member, Information Intelligence Working Group, Purdue University**
Interdisciplinary development of an "information intelligence" program for youth and civic organizations.

Discipline

2026 | **MPSA**
Discussant

2025 | **Polarization Consortium Workshop**
Discussant

2025 | **APSA**
Chair

2025 | **SPSA**
Discussant and Chair

2024 | **National Institute of Standards and Technology AI Safety Institute Consortium**
Member of Working Group on Synthetic Content

2023 | **APSA, MPSA, WPSA**
Discussant

Journalism Experience

Reporter & Staff Writer

2004-2018 | **Freelance**
Based in India, Egypt and Silicon Valley. Reporting from 19 countries for over 100 outlets.

Summer 2017 | **Etc Göteborg**
Gothenburg, Sweden

Summer 2016 | **KIT**
Stockholm, Sweden

Spring 2008 | **CNET News**
San Francisco, U.S.

Summer 2007 | **Dagens Industri**
Stockholm, Sweden

Summer 2006 | **Göteborgs-Posten**
Gothenburg, Sweden

Spring 2006 | **Veckans Affärer**
Stockholm, Sweden

Memberships

American Political Science Association, Midwest Political Science Association, Southern Political Science Association

References

Cherie D. Maestas
Associate Dean of Research, Innovation, and Graduate Education, College of Liberal Arts, Professor of Political Science, Purdue University.
cmaestas@purdue.edu.
Dissertation Chair.

Kathryn Cramer Brownell
Professor in History, and Director of Center for American Political History, Media, and Technology, Purdue University.
brownell@purdue.edu.
Postdoctoral Supervisor.

Daniel Schiff
Associate Professor in Political Science and Co-director of Governance and Responsible AI Lab, Purdue University.
dschiff@purdue.edu.
Postdoctoral Advisor.